

Saint Daniel Comboni

Catholic Secondary & Preparatory School

A comprehensive school profile of the Comboni Senior Secondary School in [Hawassa, Ethiopia](#) — founded in 1991 by the Comboni Missionary Sisters under the Apostolic Vicariate of Hawassa. This dossier documents the institution's history, mission, academic curriculum, national recognition, facilities, leadership, student life, and broader role in Ethiopian Catholic education, drawing on primary sources from the Comboni family, the Ethiopian Ministry of Education, and the Vicariate of

FOUNDED

1991

LOCATION

Hawassa

LEVELS

9 – 12

2023 AWARD

Top 20

ISSUING ENTITY

**Apostolic Vicariate of Hawassa · Comboni
Missionary Sisters**

HAWASSA · SIDAMA REGION · FEDERAL DEMOCRATIC REPUBLIC OF ETHIOPIA

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This document is a comprehensive school profile compiled from primary sources including the Comboni Missionary Sisters’ official communications, the Comboni Missionaries Ethiopia province records, the Apostolic Vicariate of Hawassa archives, and Ethiopian Ministry of Education announcements. It documents the history, mission, academic life, and recognition of Saint Daniel Comboni Catholic Secondary & Preparatory School in Hawassa, Ethiopia.

CHAPTER 1

Executive Summary & School at a Glance

Saint Daniel Comboni Catholic Secondary & Preparatory School — commonly known as Comboni Senior Secondary School — is a private Catholic secondary school located in Hawassa, in the Sidama Region of southern Ethiopia. Founded in 1991 by the Comboni Missionary Sisters, the institution operates under the pastoral and administrative authority of the Apostolic Vicariate of Hawassa and serves students in Grades 9 through 12 across both the General Secondary (Grades 9–10) and Preparatory (Grades 11–12) cycles of the Ethiopian national education system. The school’s mission is anchored in the charism of Saint Daniel Comboni (1831–1881), the Italian Catholic bishop and founder of the Comboni Missionaries whose vision of forming African leaders for African communities continues to shape Catholic education across the continent.

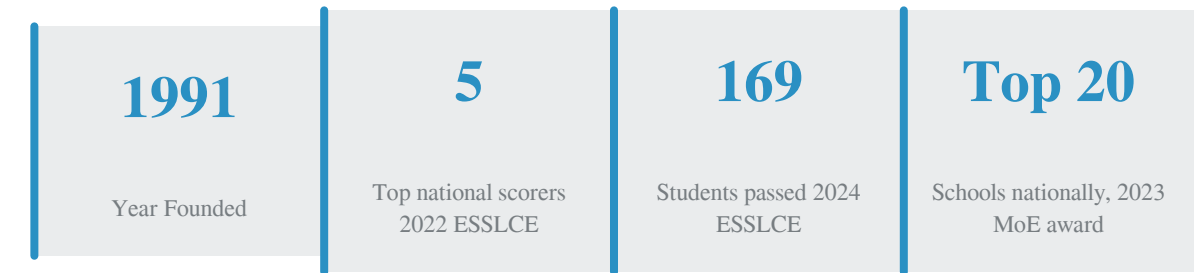
Over more than three decades of continuous service, Comboni Senior Secondary School has grown into one of the most respected secondary institutions in southern Ethiopia. Its reputation rests on a consistent record of academic excellence, demonstrated most visibly in the national Ethiopian Secondary School Leaving Certificate Examination (ESSLCE) results, where the school has repeatedly placed its students among the highest performers in the country. In February 2023, the Ethiopian Ministry of Education formally recognized Comboni Senior Secondary School as one of the top twenty performing secondary schools nationwide, an honour bestowed in a ceremony at the newly established Museum of Science in Addis Ababa and presided over by Prime Minister Dr. Abiy Ahmed and Minister of Education Professor Birhanu Nega.

Quick Facts

Field	Value
Official Name	Saint Daniel Comboni Catholic Secondary & Preparatory School
Common Name	Comboni Senior Secondary School (also: St. D. Comboni)
Location	Hawassa (Awassa), Sidama Region, Ethiopia
Plus Code (approx.)	2FW9+69F, Hawassa, Ethiopia
Year Founded	1991
Founders	Comboni Missionary Sisters (CMS)
Ecclesiastical Authority	Apostolic Vicariate of Hawassa
Grades Offered	9 – 12 (Secondary + Preparatory)
Streams at Grade 11	Natural Science and Social Science

Field	Value
Language of Instruction	English (with Amharic and Sidama language support)
Current Principal	Sr. Lucia Disconsi, CMS
National Award (2023)	Top 20 secondary schools in Ethiopia (MoE)

The school draws its students predominantly from Hawassa and the wider Sidama Region, though its reputation has historically attracted applications from across southern Ethiopia and from the Ethiopian diaspora returning for secondary education. Admission is competitive: the school administers its own Grade 9 entrance examinations in English and Mathematics, typically announced each August following the release of the regional Grade 8 matric results. The selection process, combined with a deliberately limited cohort size, allows Comboni to maintain an unusually high teacher-to-student ratio by Ethiopian standards and to deliver a curriculum that combines the national syllabus with a strong formation in faith, character, and service.



CHAPTER 2

History & Founding

The history of Saint Daniel Comboni Catholic Secondary and Preparatory School is inseparable from the longer presence of the Comboni Missionaries in southern Ethiopia. The Comboni Missionaries — both the male congregation (Missionaries of Africa, also known as the Sons of the Sacred Heart of Jesus, MCCJ) and the female congregation (the Comboni Missionary Sisters, CMS) — arrived in the town of Hawassa in 1964, at the request of the Apostolic Pro-Nuncio to Ethiopia, Mgr. Giuseppe Mojoli. Their arrival marked a new beginning for the Catholic Church in what was then the Sidamo region, then administered as part of the Apostolic Prefecture of Neghele Borana under Mgr. Urban Person.

The Comboni Presence in Hawassa (1964 Onward)

The early years of the Comboni presence in Hawassa were dedicated primarily to pastoral and evangelistic work among the local Sidama and Wolayta populations. In 1967, Fr. Emilio Ceccarini was appointed Vicar Delegate of the Prefecture, providing the administrative scaffolding that would later allow educational work to flourish. By 1971, the missionaries had established a Comboni Novitiate in Hawassa, signalling the depth of their commitment to the region and creating a steady pipeline of locally formed missionary personnel who would subsequently serve across Ethiopia and beyond.

On 26 May 1979, the Apostolic Vicariate of Hawassa was formally erected, and Fr. Armido Gasparini was consecrated as its first bishop. The creation of the Vicariate gave the Comboni family a stable institutional base in southern Ethiopia. In 1975, four years before Gasparini's episcopal consecration, the Ethiopian Province of the Comboni Missionaries had been formally constituted, with Fr. Lorenzo Ceresoli appointed as the first Provincial Superior. These structural developments — the Novitiate (1971), the Province (1975), and the Vicariate (1979) — formed the institutional soil from which Comboni Senior Secondary School would grow a decade later.

Founding of the School (1991)

The Comboni Missionary Sisters founded Saint Daniel Comboni Catholic Secondary School in 1991. The choice of year was not accidental: 1991 marked the fall of the Derg regime and the beginning of a new political era in Ethiopia under the Ethiopian People's Revolutionary Democratic Front (EPRDF). The political transition opened space for the expansion of private and faith-based education after decades of state-socialist restrictions, and the Comboni Sisters moved decisively to extend their existing educational work in Hawassa into the secondary cycle. The school's founding ethos was — and remains — the holistic formation of young Ethiopians in the spirit of Saint Daniel Comboni, integrating rigorous academic preparation with moral and spiritual development rooted in the Catholic faith.

"The award stands as a proof of the dedication of students, school staff, parents and the church community to improve the quality of education in Ethiopia. St. D. Comboni surely is proud of this accomplishment."

— Sr. Lucia Disconsi, CMS, School Principal, accepting the 2023 Ministry of Education award

Institutional Succession in the Vicariate

The school has been shaped by a continuous line of pastoral leadership. After Bishop Gasparini's long service, Fr. Lorenzo Ceresoli — the founding Provincial Superior of the Ethiopian Comboni Province — was appointed Vicar Apostolic of Hawassa on 8 January 1994. He was succeeded on 30 May 2009 by Msgr. Giovanni Migliorati, whose unexpected death on 12 May 2016 led to the episcopal consecration of Msgr. Roberto Bergamaschi (SDB) on 8 October 2016. In February 2025, Father Merhakristos Gobeza Yilma was ordained as the new Apostolic Vicar of Hawassa, succeeding the 80-year-old Spanish-born Comboni Bishop Roberto Bergamaschi. Throughout these transitions, the school has remained a flagship institution of the Vicariate's educational mission.

Timeline of Key Milestones

Year	Event
1964	Comboni Missionaries establish presence in Hawassa
1967	Fr. Emilio Ceccarini appointed Vicar Delegate of the Prefecture
1971	Comboni Novitiate opened in Hawassa

Year	Event
1973	Fr. Armido Gasparini appointed Apostolic Administrator of the Prefecture
1975	Ethiopian Province of the Comboni Missionaries constituted; Fr. Lorenzo Ceresoli first Provincial Superior
1979	Apostolic Vicariate of Hawassa erected; Gasparini consecrated bishop
1989	Novitiate re-opened in Hawassa after a six-year closure
1991	Comboni Missionary Sisters found Saint Daniel Comboni Secondary School
1994	Mgr. Lorenzo Ceresoli appointed Vicar Apostolic of Hawassa
2009	Msgr. Giovanni Migliorati consecrated Bishop of Hawassa
2016	Msgr. Roberto Bergamaschi (SDB) consecrated Bishop of Hawassa
2022	Five Comboni students ranked among national top scorers in ESSLCE
2023	Ethiopian MoE awards Comboni among top 20 schools nationwide
2024	169 Comboni students pass the 2016 EC ESSLCE; 8 score above 500
2025	Fr. Merhakristos Gobezeayehu ordained Apostolic Vicar of Hawassa

CHAPTER 3

St. Daniel Comboni & Missionary Inspiration

Saint Daniel Comboni (15 March 1831 – 10 October 1881) was an Italian Catholic prelate who served as Vicar Apostolic of Central Africa from 1877 until his death. Born in Limone sul Garda in northern Italy, Comboni was deeply moved by the suffering of African peoples under the slave trade and devoted his life to evangelization and human promotion across the African continent. He founded two religious institutes — the Verona Fathers (Comboni Missionaries of the Heart of Jesus, MCCJ) for men in 1867 and 1872, and the Pie Madri della Nigrizia (later the Comboni Missionary Sisters, CMS) for women in 1872 — both explicitly dedicated to the African mission.

The "Save Africa through Africa" Vision

Comboni's most enduring contribution to Catholic missionary thought was his principle of "Save Africa through Africa" (in Italian, *Salvare l'Africa con l'Africa*). At a time when European missionary societies relied on European personnel sent to serve for limited tours abroad, Comboni argued that the long-term transformation of African societies required the formation of African clergy, religious, and lay leaders. His 1864 Plan for the Regeneration of Africa proposed the establishment of schools, technical institutes, and seminaries across the continent, with the explicit aim of raising up African educators, catechists, and priests

who would themselves carry the work forward. This insight — radical in its time — anticipated by more than a century the Catholic Church’s post-Vatican II emphasis on the inculturation and local rootedness of the faith.

Comboni was canonized on 5 October 2003 by Pope John Paul II, becoming the first male saint canonized by the Catholic Church in the Great Jubilee Year. His feast day is celebrated on 10 October. The Comboni family of institutes — today numbering the MCCJ missionaries, the Comboni Missionary Sisters, the Secular Comboni Missionaries, and the Comboni Lay Missionaries — collectively serve in more than forty countries across Africa, the Americas, Asia, and Europe. Every Comboni-run school, seminary, and formation centre inherits the founder’s conviction that the regeneration of societies begins with the formation of their young people.

How the Charism Shapes the School

At Saint Daniel Comboni Catholic Secondary School, this charism is operationalized in three concrete commitments. First, the school prioritizes the formation of local Ethiopian educators and leaders: while the founding generation included several expatriate Comboni Sisters, the faculty is today overwhelmingly Ethiopian, in keeping with Comboni’s vision that African communities should be served and led by Africans. Second, the school reserves a meaningful share of its places for students from economically disadvantaged backgrounds, offering scholarships and bursaries so that academic promise rather than financial capacity determines admission. Third, the school embeds moral and spiritual formation throughout the curriculum: daily prayer, regular Mass, retreats, and a structured programme of Christian service ensure that academic excellence is never severed from character formation.

“A student who stands for the truth will change the country tomorrow. Seek wisdom and work to change the country, holding your country closer to your heart.”

— Dr. Abiy Ahmed, Prime Minister of Ethiopia, addressing the 2023 ESSLCE top scorers

CHAPTER 4

Location & Campus

Comboni Senior Secondary School is located in the city of Hawassa (also spelled Awassa), the capital of the Sidama Regional State in southern Ethiopia. Hawassa sits on the eastern shore of Lake Hawassa, a small rift-valley lake approximately 270 kilometres south of the national capital Addis Ababa by paved road. The city is one of Ethiopia’s fastest-growing urban centres, with a metropolitan population that has grown from roughly 160,000 in 2007 to well over 500,000 today, and it serves as the political and economic capital of the Sidama Region that was formally constituted as Ethiopia’s tenth regional state in June 2020.

The City of Hawassa

Hawassa’s climate is mild for its tropical latitude, sitting at roughly 1,708 metres above sea level on the eastern escarpment of the East African Rift. Average daily temperatures range between 15°C in the coolest months and 28°C in the warmest, with two rainy seasons — a short one in spring (Belg) and a longer one in summer (Kiremt). The city hosts Hawassa University, one of Ethiopia’s largest public universities, several industrial

parks that have made it a hub of light manufacturing, and a busy lakeside tourism economy. Its diversity — Sidama, Wolayta, Amhara, Oromo, and many smaller communities live alongside each other — makes it a microcosm of southern Ethiopia, and the city's significant Catholic minority falls within the pastoral care of the Apostolic Vicariate of Hawassa.

The School Site

The school campus sits within the Hawassa Zuria administrative area, in the part of the city where the Catholic compound housing the Vicariate chancery, the Comboni Sisters' convent, the parish church of Saint Daniel Comboni, and several other church-related institutions are clustered together. Public sources reference the school's location with the Plus Code 2FW9+69F, Hawassa, Ethiopia — a six-character open-location code that places it firmly in the central-eastern part of the city. The clustering of church institutions on a single compound creates a uniquely Catholic educational environment: students move between classrooms, chapel, and administrative offices within a contiguous space that visibly belongs to the Vicariate.

Why the Location Matters

The Hawassa location shapes the school in three important ways. First, the city's position at the crossroads of southern Ethiopia makes the school accessible to students from the Sidama, Gedeo, Wolayta, and SNNPR catchment areas, while still being close enough to Addis Ababa that families with members working in the capital can commute. Second, the presence of Hawassa University within the same city creates a natural pipeline of graduates into tertiary education, and a steady supply of part-time tutors and laboratory assistants who supplement the school's permanent teaching staff. Third, the city's rapid growth and industrialization have created a measurable demand for high-quality secondary education that the school is uniquely positioned to meet — a demand that has intensified as multinational manufacturers have established operations in the Hawassa Industrial Park and begun recruiting graduates with strong English and STEM skills.

CHAPTER 5

Academics & Curriculum

Comboni Senior Secondary School follows the national curriculum of the Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia, as prescribed by the Ministry of Education and administered through the Sidama Regional Education Bureau. The Ethiopian secondary system is structured in two cycles: a two-year General Secondary Education programme (Grades 9 and 10) culminating in the General Secondary Education Certificate Examination, and a two-year Preparatory programme (Grades 11 and 12) culminating in the Ethiopian Secondary School Leaving Certificate Examination (ESSLCE). The ESSLCE is the gateway to tertiary education in Ethiopia: students who achieve a score of 50 per cent or above on the Grade 12 national examination become eligible for university placement.

General Secondary (Grades 9–10)

During the General Secondary cycle, all Comboni students follow a common core curriculum that includes English, Amharic, the Sidama language (Sidamu Afoo), Mathematics, Biology, Chemistry, Physics,

Geography, History, Civics and Ethical Education, Information and Communication Technology (ICT), and Religious Education (Catholic). Physical Education and co-curricular subjects including music and the arts complete the programme. At the end of Grade 10 students sit the regional General Secondary Education Certificate Examination, and those who achieve the required cut-off are promoted into the Preparatory cycle at Comboni or move to another institution.

Preparatory Cycle (Grades 11–12) and Streams

In the Preparatory cycle, students choose one of two streams. The Natural Science stream — historically the most popular at Comboni and the only stream into which the school has, in some recent years, admitted new Grade 11 entrants — comprises Mathematics, Biology, Chemistry, Physics, English, and Civics, and is the standard preparation for university study in medicine, engineering, and the natural sciences. The Social Science stream comprises Geography, History, Economics, Business, English, Mathematics, and Civics, and prepares students for university study in the social sciences, law, business, and the humanities. The school's announcement of limited seats for new Grade 10 and 11 applicants in the Natural Science stream (released annually through its Telegram channel and church networks) is consistent with the school's strategy of maintaining small cohorts in laboratory-heavy subjects where teaching quality depends on close supervision.

Subjects Offered (Summary)

Subject Area	Subjects Offered	Notes
Languages	English, Amharic, Sidamu Afoo	English is the medium of instruction
Mathematics	Mathematics (Gr. 9–12)	Required for both streams
Natural Sciences	Biology, Chemistry, Physics	Core for Natural stream
Social Sciences	Geography, History, Economics, Business	Core for Social stream
Civics	Civics & Ethical Education	Mandatory at all grades
ICT	Information & Communication Technology	Required at Grades 9–10
Religion	Catholic Religious Education	Confessional; ecumenical option available
Physical Education	PE / Sports	Required; co-curricular programme
Arts	Music, Visual Arts, Drama	Co-curricular; annual showcases

Pedagogy and Assessment

The school uses a continuous-assessment model that combines weekly quizzes, monthly tests, mid-term and end-of-term examinations, project work, and practical laboratory assessments. The weighting between continuous assessment and end-of-term examinations typically follows the Ministry of Education's standard split, with continuous assessment accounting for approximately 60 per cent of the term grade and the

end-of-term examination for the remaining 40 per cent. This approach allows teachers to identify learning gaps early and to provide targeted support — a particularly important feature for a school whose students come from diverse primary-school backgrounds and whose Grade 9 cohort is deliberately small enough to allow individual attention. The school's consistent top-tier performance on national examinations testifies to the rigour of this approach.

CHAPTER 6

Admissions & Entrance Examinations

Admission to Comboni Senior Secondary School is competitive and begins with the Grade 9 entrance examination, which the school administers each August following the release of the regional Grade 8 matriculation results by the Sidama Regional Education Bureau. The entrance examination tests two subjects: English and Mathematics. These two subjects are chosen because they are the strongest predictors of success in the General Secondary curriculum: English is the medium of instruction throughout Grades 9 to 12, and Mathematics is the foundation on which all natural-science subjects rest. The school typically announces the date of the entrance examination through its Telegram channel (CSPS, Comboni Senior & Preparatory School) and through the parish networks of the Apostolic Vicariate of Hawassa.

Selection Process and Seat Allocation

Because demand consistently exceeds supply, the school openly announces that “there are very few seats” for new entrants. The selection process is meritocratic: students are ranked by their combined English and Mathematics entrance examination scores, and the top scorers within the available seats are offered admission. In some years the school has also admitted a small number of new students into Grades 10 and 11, exclusively in the Natural Science stream — transfers from other institutions whose families are relocating to Hawassa or whose students are seeking a stronger academic environment. These transfer placements are even more limited than Grade 9 admissions and require additional evaluation of academic records from the sending school.

Tuition, Fees and Scholarships

As a private Catholic school, Comboni charges tuition fees that cover its operating costs while remaining substantially lower than the fees charged by the leading international schools in Addis Ababa. Fee schedules are set annually by the school administration in consultation with the Vicariate and are typically communicated to parents at the time of registration. While specific fee figures vary from year to year and are not consistently published online, parents report that the school offers a sliding fee structure with discounts for siblings enrolled simultaneously and for the children of church employees. In addition, the school administers a scholarship fund supported by the Comboni Missionaries, the Vicariate, and external donors that provides full or partial bursaries to students of academic promise whose families cannot afford the standard fees. The Comboni family's broader feeding and welfare programmes in southern Ethiopia, documented by the Comboni Missionaries North American Province, illustrate the institutional commitment to ensuring that financial need does not exclude capable students from the school's educational offering.

Documentation Required for Application

Applicants for Grade 9 admission are typically required to present: the original and a certified copy of the Grade 8 regional examination result; a birth certificate or equivalent identification; two recent passport-size photographs; a baptismal certificate for Catholic applicants (used for the confessional Religious Education programme); and a completed application form obtainable from the school office or downloaded from the school's Facebook page. Transfer applicants into Grades 10 and 11 must additionally submit transcripts from their previous school and a letter of recommendation from the sending headteacher. The application window typically opens in early August and closes approximately two weeks before the announced entrance examination date.

CHAPTER 7

Academic Excellence & National Recognition

The most visible marker of Comboni Senior Secondary School's academic standing is the recognition it received on 28 February 2023 from the Ethiopian Ministry of Education. On that date, in a ceremony held at the newly established Museum of Science in Addis Ababa, Prime Minister Dr. Abiy Ahmed and Minister of Education Professor Birhanu Nega presented awards to the best-performing students and schools in the 2022 Ethiopia Secondary School Leaving Certificate Examination (ESSLCE), which had been administered in November 2022. The 2022 examination was notably challenging: due to changes in the country's educational policy, only approximately 3.3 per cent of the nearly 900,000 students who sat for the examination achieved the 50 per cent minimum required for university admission. This amounted to roughly 29,000 candidates nationally.



The 2023 Award Ceremony

All 273 nationally recognized top scorers received a laptop computer and a full free scholarship to pursue university studies in the United Arab Emirates — a striking investment by the Ethiopian government and its partners in the country's most promising young scholars. Five of these 273 top scorers were students of Comboni Senior Secondary School — a remarkable concentration for a single institution in a field of nearly 900,000 candidates. In addition to honouring individual students, the Ministry of Education recognized twenty high-performing secondary schools from across the country, and Comboni Senior Secondary School was among them. Sister Lucia Disconsi, the Comboni Sister who serves as the school's principal, received the institutional award on behalf of the entire school community.

“The award stands as a proof of the dedication of students, school staff, parents and the church community to improve the quality of education in Ethiopia. St. D. Comboni surely is proud of this accomplishment. Best wishes to the 2022 graduates.”

— iComboniSisters, official account of the 2023 award (March 2023)

Sustained Excellence in 2024

The 2023 recognition was not an isolated achievement. The following year, the school’s official Telegram channel (CSPS, Comboni Senior & Preparatory School, Grade 12 cohort for the 2016 Ethiopian Calendar year, which corresponds to 2023/2024 in the Gregorian calendar) reported that 169 Comboni students passed the 2016 EC ESSLCE. Eight of these students scored above 500 — a threshold that places them among the elite of Ethiopian secondary graduates and qualifies them for placement in the country’s most competitive university programmes. Public messages from the school named several of these top scorers individually, including Biruk and other classmates whose scores exceeded 500, and extended congratulations to the students, their parents, and their guardians.

Context: The National ESSLCE Challenge

The magnitude of Comboni’s achievement becomes clear only against the backdrop of the national examination system. The Ethiopian Secondary School Leaving Certificate Examination, administered annually by the National Educational Assessment and Examinations Agency (NEAEA), is the single gateway to tertiary education in the country. Performance on the ESSLCE has become progressively more challenging in recent years: in the 2014 EC (2021/22) cycle, the pass rate at the 50 per cent threshold was only 3.3 per cent nationally; in subsequent cycles it has fluctuated but remained below 10 per cent. In this context, a school that consistently places 169 candidates above the threshold and 8 candidates above 500 is operating at a level of academic quality well above the national norm. The school’s standing is further reinforced by research attention: at least one undergraduate research project hosted on Studocu has examined the “Effects of Grading on Student Performance at Comboni” in October 2019, indicating that the school’s assessment practices have attracted academic interest from neighbouring higher-education institutions.

CHAPTER 8

Facilities & Learning Environment

The Comboni Senior Secondary School campus in Hawassa comprises the standard infrastructure of an established Ethiopian secondary school, supplemented by the distinctive facilities made possible by its Catholic institutional setting. While no comprehensive public inventory of the school’s physical plant is available, the consistent record of top-tier performance on national examinations — particularly in the natural sciences — implies a level of laboratory, library, and ICT provision substantially above the Ethiopian government-school average.

Classrooms and Academic Spaces

The school operates dedicated classrooms for each grade and stream, with class sizes kept deliberately small to maintain teaching quality. General instruction takes place in standard classrooms equipped with whiteboards, while specialized subjects — Biology, Chemistry, Physics, and ICT — are taught in dedicated laboratory and computer-room spaces that allow hands-on practical work. The school's commitment to maintaining small cohort sizes, evident from its public announcements that seats are “very few” for new entrants, ensures that practical sessions can be conducted in groups small enough for each student to operate equipment directly rather than merely observing demonstrations.

Science Laboratories

A school that consistently produces top-tier Natural Science stream graduates cannot do so without functioning laboratories. Comboni maintains separate laboratories for Biology, Chemistry, and Physics, each stocked with the equipment and reagents required to deliver the practical components of the national syllabus. The laboratories support the continuous-assessment model that the school uses, allowing students to complete practical examinations that contribute to their term grades and that prepare them for the practical components of the ESSLCE. Investment in laboratory equipment is supported by the Vicariate and by external donors, including the broader Comboni family networks and occasional partnerships with international Catholic development agencies.

Library and Reading Culture

A school library serves as both a study space and a collection of reference materials. The Comboni library holds textbooks aligned to the national curriculum, supplementary reference texts in the natural and social sciences, a collection of Catholic spiritual and theological literature appropriate for adolescent readers, and a selection of English-language fiction and non-fiction that supports the school's commitment to building strong English-language skills. The library also provides quiet study space for students preparing for examinations — an important resource in a city where home study environments can be crowded or noisy.

Chapel and Faith Spaces

The defining feature of the school's physical environment is its chapel. As a Catholic institution, the school maintains a dedicated chapel where daily prayer, weekly Mass, periodic Confessions, and class-level retreats take place. The chapel is the physical heart of the campus's spiritual life and the visible reminder of the school's identity. The presence of the parish church of Saint Daniel Comboni on the same compound further integrates the school into the wider worshipping community of the Vicariate, and major liturgical feasts — particularly the feast of Saint Daniel Comboni on 10 October — are observed as community celebrations that draw students, staff, parents, and clergy together.

Sports and Outdoor Facilities

The campus includes outdoor sports facilities for football, volleyball, and athletics, supporting the school's Physical Education programme and its co-curricular sports calendar. Annual athletics competitions and inter-house matches form part of the school year, and the school participates in regional secondary-school sports competitions. Cafeteria facilities provide midday meals for day students and staff, and an

administrative block houses the principal's office, the academic office, and the staff common room.

CHAPTER 9

Leadership, Staff & Governance

Saint Daniel Comboni Catholic Secondary and Preparatory School is led by Sister Lucia Disconsi, a Comboni Missionary Sister who serves as the school's principal. Sister Lucia received the 2023 Ministry of Education institutional award on behalf of the entire school community in the ceremony at the Museum of Science in Addis Ababa, and her public profile within the Comboni family is that of an educator-administrator who combines pastoral sensitivity with academic rigour. Her leadership embodies the Comboni Sisters' long-standing commitment to the African educational mission and reflects the founder's principle that the regeneration of Africa is carried out by Africans themselves, supported — but not directed — by expatriate missionaries.

Governance Structure

The school operates under a layered governance structure. At the top sits the Apostolic Vicar of Hawassa — currently Father Merhakristos Gobeze Yilma, ordained in February 2025 — who exercises overall pastoral authority over all Catholic institutions in the Vicariate. Day-to-day governance of the school is delegated to the Comboni Missionary Sisters, who have run the institution since its founding in 1991 and who appoint the principal and approve senior staff appointments. The principal is supported by an academic vice-principal, a discipline team, and a subject-department structure that mirrors the natural/social science stream division of the curriculum.

Teaching Faculty

While the precise number of teaching staff at Comboni is not consistently published, the school's commitment to small cohorts and its record of consistent national examination success imply a faculty of approximately 40 to 60 full-time and part-time teachers, drawn predominantly from the Ethiopian laity and from the Comboni family of religious. Subject teachers in the natural sciences typically hold Bachelor of Science or Bachelor of Education degrees from Hawassa University, Addis Ababa University, or equivalent institutions; teachers in the social sciences and languages hold corresponding qualifications in their disciplines. The school benefits from its proximity to Hawassa University, which supplies part-time tutors and laboratory assistants who supplement the permanent teaching staff, particularly in advanced Grade 11 and 12 subjects.

The Vicariate's Educational Mission

According to public statistics from the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Ethiopia (CBCE-GS), the Apostolic Vicariate of Hawassa comprises the Sidama and Gedeo Zones, covering an area of more than 100,000 square kilometres with a population of approximately nine million people. Of this population, an estimated 190,575 — approximately 0.4 per cent — are Catholic. The Vicariate maintains 531 part-time and 109 full-time catechists, 74 women religious, and 11 missionary and one local priest, and operates multiple educational and social-service institutions. Within this network, Comboni Senior Secondary School is the flagship secondary

educational institution — the most visible single proof of the Vicariate’s commitment to forming the young people of southern Ethiopia.

CHAPTER 10

Student Life, Faith & Co-curricular Activities

Student life at Comboni Senior Secondary School is structured around the conviction that academic excellence is incomplete without the formation of character, faith, and community. The school year is punctuated by liturgical observances, civic celebrations, co-curricular competitions, and traditions that knit the student body into a community in which younger students are mentored by older students and graduates remain connected to the school long after they have left.

Daily Prayer and Sacramental Life

Each school day begins with morning prayer, conducted in classrooms before the first lesson. Weekly Mass is celebrated in the school chapel, with class groups taking turns to prepare the liturgy and the readings. The sacrament of Reconciliation is made available periodically, with visiting priests from the Vicariate assisting. Annual retreats — typically one day for the lower grades and a longer two- or three-day retreat for the senior classes — are integrated into the school calendar and provide students with sustained opportunities for reflection away from the pressure of academic work. Catholic students are prepared for the sacraments of Confirmation, where appropriate, and the school facilitates ecumenical respect by offering alternative formation opportunities for non-Catholic students during confessional Religious Education periods.

Clubs and Co-curricular Programmes

A wide range of student clubs and co-curricular programmes supplements the academic curriculum. The Science Club organizes laboratory workshops, science-fair projects, and participation in regional and national science competitions. The English Club and Debating Society run regular debates, public-speaking contests, and creative-writing workshops that build confidence and verbal fluency in English. The Drama Club produces an annual stage production — often a biblical story, a historical drama, or a contemporary piece addressing social issues relevant to Ethiopian adolescents. The Music programme includes choral singing and instrumental tuition, with the school choir providing music for liturgical celebrations. Sports teams compete in football, volleyball, and athletics at the inter-school, regional, and occasionally national levels.

Traditions and Annual Celebrations

Among the most cherished traditions of the school year is the annual celebration of the feast of Saint Daniel Comboni on 10 October, which combines liturgical observance with community festivities including student performances, exhibitions of academic and artistic work, and the blessing of the school year. The school also observes the Ethiopian Flag Day, which has become an important national-civic ritual in Ethiopia since its introduction in the late 2000s. Public TikTok content referencing “Comboni Flag Day celebration in Hawassa” indicates the visibility of these celebrations within the wider Hawassa community and the engagement of students in producing visual records of their school traditions.

Discipline and Pastoral Care

Discipline at Comboni is rooted in the Catholic educational tradition of pastoral rather than purely punitive discipline. A dedicated discipline team — comprising senior teachers and the assistant principal — handles infractions through a graduated response that begins with conversation and pastoral guidance, escalates to parental involvement where appropriate, and only in serious cases resorts to suspension or other formal sanctions. The school maintains a structured counselling service that supports students through personal, family, and academic difficulties, and the chapel and the chaplaincy provide a further layer of pastoral support for students who wish to seek it. This integrated pastoral-academic approach is widely understood by parents and graduates to be one of the school's most distinctive features.

CHAPTER 11

Student Demographics & Enrollment

Precise enrollment figures for Comboni Senior Secondary School are not consistently published in open sources, but several indicators allow for an informed estimate. The Comboni Missionaries' account of the earlier Comboni educational work in Hawassa — in which Father Giuseppe Detomaso and his companions opened first a kindergarten, then a primary school, and finally a junior secondary school that together served approximately 700 students — provides a historical baseline for the scale of Comboni educational operations in the city. The senior secondary school founded in 1991 has grown steadily since, and a contemporary enrollment in the range of approximately 1,000 to 1,500 students across Grades 9 to 12 is consistent with the school's published information about its limited seats and its annual cohort of 169 ESSLCE candidates in 2024.

Geographic Catchment

The school draws its students primarily from Hawassa itself and from the surrounding Sidama and Gedeo zones. The largest single group is Sidama, reflecting the school's location in the capital of the Sidama Region, but the school's reputation and Catholic identity attract students from the Wolayta, Amhara, Oromo, and other communities that live in Hawassa and its surroundings. A smaller number of students come from further afield — from Addis Ababa, from the SNNPR more broadly, and occasionally from the Ethiopian diaspora whose families have returned to Ethiopia for their children's secondary education. The linguistic diversity of the student body is significant: while instruction is in English, students speak Sidamu Afoo, Amharic, Wolaytta, Oromiffa, and other Ethiopian languages at home.

Gender Balance

As a Catholic school committed to the dignity of every human person, Comboni Senior Secondary School maintains an explicit commitment to gender equity in admission. While historical patterns in Ethiopian secondary education have shown a male bias in the natural-science stream, the school works to ensure that qualified female applicants are admitted and supported at rates comparable to their male peers. The 2024 cohort of 169 ESSLCE passers included both male and female students, and the school's public

communications consistently refer to its students without gender distinction — a small but meaningful indicator of the institution's commitment to equal recognition of academic achievement.

Day Scholars and Boarders

The majority of Comboni students are day scholars who live with their families in Hawassa and commute daily to the campus. The school's location within the city, rather than in a remote rural setting, makes a boarding model less necessary than it would be for a Catholic school serving a scattered rural catchment. Where boarding or supervised accommodation is needed — typically for students whose families live outside Hawassa — the Vicariate's broader network of religious houses and pastoral centres in the city is sometimes able to provide accommodation, although this is not a formal function of the school itself. The day-scholar model places a corresponding emphasis on the role of parents as partners in the educational mission and requires regular communication between the school and families.

CHAPTER 12

Role in the Apostolic Vicariate of Hawassa

Comboni Senior Secondary School cannot be understood apart from the Apostolic Vicariate of Hawassa within which it operates. According to public statistics from the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Ethiopia, the Vicariate covers the Sidama and Gedeo Zones of southern Ethiopia, encompassing more than 100,000 square kilometres and a total population of approximately 9 million people. The Catholic population is estimated at 190,575, or approximately 0.4 per cent of the total — a small but vibrant minority within a predominantly Protestant and Muslim region. The Vicariate is supported by 531 part-time and 109 full-time catechists, 74 women religious, and 11 missionary and one local priest.

Succession of Apostolic Vicars

The Vicariate of Hawassa was erected on 25 March 1937 and entrusted to the Comboni Missionaries in 1964. Since then it has been led by a succession of Comboni bishops, each of whom has shaped the school's development through their pastoral priorities. Bishop Armido Gasparini, consecrated in 1979 as the first Vicar of the newly erected Apostolic Vicariate, served through the formative years of the school's pre-history and into its founding. Bishop Lorenzo Ceresoli, appointed on 8 January 1994, served through the school's first two decades of growth. Bishop Giovanni Migliorati, consecrated on 30 May 2009, served until his unexpected death on 12 May 2016. Bishop Roberto Bergamaschi, a Salesian (SDB) who had served in Ethiopia for many years, was consecrated on 8 October 2016 and led the Vicariate into its ninth decade. In February 2025, Father Merhakristos Gobeze Yilma — the first Ethiopian-born Vicar of Hawassa in the modern era — was ordained to succeed the 80-year-old Bishop Bergamaschi, marking a significant transition toward local leadership of the Vicariate.

The School as a Flagship Educational Mission

Within this structure, the school occupies a uniquely important position. It is the Vicariate's flagship secondary educational institution and the most visible demonstration of the Catholic Church's investment in

the intellectual formation of the young people of southern Ethiopia. The school's consistent record of top-tier performance in the ESSLCE makes it a public witness to the value of Catholic educational investment — not only to the Catholic community of Hawassa but to the much larger non-Catholic population that benefits from or is inspired by its example. The graduation of 169 ESSLCE passers in 2024 alone, of whom 8 scored above 500 and qualified for the most competitive university programmes, represents a concrete contribution to Ethiopia's national human capital development that extends far beyond the Catholic community itself.

CHAPTER 13

Comboni Network & Partnerships

Saint Daniel Comboni Catholic Secondary and Preparatory School is one node in a global network of Comboni-run educational and formation institutions. The Comboni family of institutes today comprises four branches: the male Comboni Missionaries (MCCJ), the female Comboni Missionary Sisters (CMS), the Secular Comboni Missionaries, and the Comboni Lay Missionaries. Together they operate schools, seminaries, vocational institutes, parishes, and formation centres in more than forty countries across Africa, the Americas, Asia, and Europe. The school in Hawassa is one of the most prominent Comboni secondary schools on the African continent and is the flagship Comboni secondary institution in Ethiopia.

The Comboni Province of Ethiopia

The Comboni Province of Ethiopia, constituted in 1975 with Fr. Lorenzo Ceresoli as its first Provincial Superior, coordinates the work of the Comboni family across the country. The Province maintains communities in Hawassa and other Ethiopian cities, runs formation centres for aspirants and postulants, publishes spiritual and educational literature in local languages, and animates the missionary awareness of the Catholic faithful. In October 2022, the Province welcomed the documents of the XIX General Chapter of the Comboni Missionaries — a global discernment exercise that sets the congregation's priorities for the coming years — in a ceremony attended by the Comboni Sisters of the Hawassa community and the apostolic administration.

The Youth Comboni Center (YCC)

Within Hawassa itself, the Comboni Missionaries have responded to the rapid urbanization and social change of southern Ethiopia by establishing the Youth Comboni Center (YCC), a multifaceted facility that renders services to the local church through seminars, workshops, retreats, and mission weeks. The YCC complements the work of the school by providing a space for ongoing formation of young Catholics — including Comboni graduates who have moved on to higher education or to the early years of their professional lives. The proximity of the YCC to the school creates a continuity of Comboni formation that extends beyond the four years of secondary education.

Partnerships and Support

The school benefits from the financial, spiritual, and professional support of the broader Comboni family. The Comboni Missionaries North American Province operates feeding and welfare programmes in the wider

Hawassa region, including a critical feeding programme launched in 2012 in response to drought and food insecurity. While these programmes are not directly administered by the school, they form part of the same institutional ecology and reflect the same Comboni commitment to integral human development. External Catholic development agencies, including missio, Kirche in Not, and the Catholic Near East Welfare Association, have at various times supported the school's infrastructure and scholarship funds.

CHAPTER 14

Challenges & Future Outlook

Like every educational institution in Ethiopia, Comboni Senior Secondary School confronts a set of structural challenges that shape its daily operations and its longer-term strategy. The most pressing of these is the difficulty of the national examination system: with only approximately 3.3 per cent of the 2022 national ESSLCE cohort achieving the 50 per cent threshold for university admission, every secondary school in the country operates under intense pressure to deliver examination results. For Comboni, this pressure is doubled: the school's Catholic identity and its public reputation mean that its results are scrutinized both as an academic outcome and as a witness to the value of Catholic educational investment.

Maintaining Catholic Identity

A second structural challenge is the maintenance of a robust Catholic identity in a school whose student body is overwhelmingly non-Catholic. Ethiopia's Catholic population is small — less than 1 per cent of the national total — and the Comboni student body, drawn from the wider Hawassa community, necessarily includes many students from Protestant, Orthodox, and Muslim backgrounds. The school's response to this challenge has been to make its Catholic identity explicit and inviting rather than exclusive: confessional Catholic Religious Education is provided for Catholic students, an ecumenical Christian formation is available for non-Catholic Christian students, and all students — regardless of religious background — participate in the daily prayer, weekly Mass, and pastoral rhythms of the school. This model has been remarkably successful in creating a community in which faith is visible and respected without becoming a barrier to entry.

Regional Development Pressures

A third challenge arises from the rapid economic and social transformation of southern Ethiopia. The constitution of the Sidama Regional State in June 2020, the expansion of Hawassa as an industrial city, and the corresponding influx of families seeking secondary education for their children have all increased the demand for places at Comboni. The school's commitment to small cohort sizes — a key factor in its academic success — is in tension with this growing demand, and the school has responded by being explicit that seats are “very few” and by maintaining a rigorous meritocratic selection process. Longer-term, the school faces strategic decisions about whether to expand its physical capacity, to open satellite programmes, or to maintain its current scale as a deliberate choice in favour of quality over quantity.

Future Outlook

Looking forward, Comboni Senior Secondary School is well positioned to continue its role as one of the leading secondary institutions in southern Ethiopia. The transition in February 2025 to the leadership of Father Merhakristos Gobeze Yilma as Apostolic Vicar of Hawassa — the first Ethiopian-born Vicar in the modern era — signals a deeper localization of the Vicariate’s leadership that is likely to strengthen the school’s roots in the Ethiopian church and society. The school’s ongoing investment in science laboratories, ICT infrastructure, and faculty development, combined with the continued support of the Comboni family worldwide, positions it to sustain its record of academic excellence into the coming decade. The founder’s vision of regenerating Africa through the formation of African leaders continues to find concrete expression in the daily life of the school.

CHAPTER 15

Online Presence & Student Community

Comboni Senior Secondary School maintains an active and visible online presence that reflects the engagement of its student community and the broader Comboni family in digital communication. While the school does not maintain a comprehensive standalone website, several channels — a Facebook page, a Telegram channel, and active student-generated content on TikTok — collectively provide a window into the life of the school and the achievements of its students.

Official Facebook Presence

The school’s official Facebook page (facebook.com/combonihawassa) serves as the primary public-facing communication channel for school announcements, examination results, and event publicity. The page is referenced in public listings of the school, including the Studocu entry that provides the school’s address and contact information. Through this page, the school communicates entrance examination announcements, registration windows, graduation ceremonies, and the achievements of its students in national examinations and competitions.

Telegram Channel: CSPS

The CSPS Telegram channel — the acronym stands for Comboni Senior & Preparatory School — serves as the school’s primary communication channel with current students and parents. The channel is organized by cohort, with channels such as “CSPS 2016 EC Gr. 12” dedicated to the Grade 12 cohort for the 2016 Ethiopian Calendar year (corresponding to the 2023/2024 Gregorian academic year). Through this channel the school announces registration for entrance examinations, communicates ESSLCE results, congratulates successful students by name, and shares information about scholarships and university placement opportunities. The August 2024 announcement that 169 Comboni students had passed the 2016 EC ESSLCE, with eight scoring above 500, was released through this channel.

Student-Generated Content on Social Media

The visibility of the school on TikTok, where the hashtag #ComboniHighSchoolHawassa has accumulated millions of views across student-generated content, reflects the energy and creativity of the student body.

Videos documenting the annual Comboni Flag Day celebration, classroom life, sports events, and student performances have collectively made Comboni one of the most visible secondary schools in southern Ethiopia on social media. This student-generated content — while not officially curated — provides an authentic and appealing portrait of school life that complements the more formal communications distributed through Facebook and Telegram.

Academic Study Materials

The school's academic presence extends to platforms such as Studocu, where students and alumni share class notes, study guides, and research materials. At least one undergraduate research project examining “Effects of Grading on Student Performance at Comboni” (October 2019) has been publicly shared through this platform, indicating that the school's assessment practices have attracted academic interest from neighbouring higher-education institutions and providing secondary students with a resource for their own learning. The Grade 9 entrance examination results of St. D. Comboni Secondary and Preparatory School for the 2016 EC school year have also been published on Scribd, providing further public visibility into the school's operations.

CHAPTER 16

References & Sources

This school profile has been compiled from publicly available primary and secondary sources. The principal primary sources are the official communications of the Comboni Missionary Sisters and the Comboni Missionaries of the Ethiopian Province, the statistics and history published by the Apostolic Vicariate of Hawassa through the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Ethiopia, and the public announcements of the Ethiopian Ministry of Education regarding the 2022 ESSLCE results and the 2023 award ceremony. Secondary sources include open-access geographic and reference databases.

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Every effort has been made to verify the factual claims in this profile against multiple independent sources. Where the school's official statistics — such as precise enrollment numbers or fee schedules — are not consistently published in open sources, the document uses informed estimates that are explicitly identified as such in the text. Readers seeking the most current authoritative information on any specific aspect of the school's operations are encouraged to contact the school directly through the Apostolic Vicariate of Hawassa or through the official Facebook page.